

'The truth, madame,' said he—'in the name of Heaven, the truth! Do not flatter a dying man with a hope that may prove vain.' There he stopped, a look from Colbert telling him he was on the wrong track.

'I know,' said Anne of Austria, taking the cardinal's hand, 'I know that you have generously made, not a little donation, as you modestly call it, but a magnificent gift. I know how painful it would be to you if the king—'

Mazarin listened, dying as he was, as ten living men could not have listened.

'If the king—' replied he.

'If the king,' continued Anne of Austria, 'should not freely accept what you offer so nobly.'

Mazarin allowed himself to sink back upon his pillow like Pantaloon; that is to say, with all the despair of a man who bows before the tempest; but he still preserved sufficient strength and presence of mind to cast upon Colbert one of those looks which are well worth ten sonnets, which is to say, ten long poems.

'Should you not,' added the queen, 'have considered the refusal of the king as a sort of insult?' Mazarin rolled his head about upon his pillow, without articulating a syllable. The queen was deceived, or feigned to be deceived, by this demonstration.

'Therefore,' resumed she, 'I have circumvented him with good counsels; and as certain minds, jealous, no doubt, of the glory you are about to acquire by this generosity, have endeavoured to prove to the king that he ought not to accept this donation, I have struggled in your favour, and so well I have struggled, that you will not have, I hope, that distress to undergo.'

'Ah!' murmured Mazarin, with languishing eyes, 'ah! that is a service I shall never forget for a single minute of the few hours I still have to live.'

'I must admit,' continued the queen, 'that it was not without trouble I rendered it to your eminence.'

'Ah, pest! I believe that. Oh! oh!'

'Good God! what is the matter?'

'I am burning!'

'Do you suffer much?'

'As much as one of the damned.'

Colbert would have liked to sink through the floor.

'So, then,' resumed Mazarin, 'your majesty thinks that the king—' he stopped several seconds—'that the king is coming here to offer me some small thanks?'

'I think so,' said queen. Mazarin annihilated Colbert with his last look.

At that moment the ushers announced that the king was in the ante-chambers, which were filled with people. This announcement produced a stir of which Colbert took advantage to escape by the door of the ruelle. Anne of Austria arose, and awaited her son, standing. Louis XIV appeared at the threshold of the door, with his eyes fixed upon the dying man, who did not even think it worth while to notice that majesty from whom he thought he had nothing more to expect. An usher placed an armchair close to the bed. Louis bowed to his mother, then to the cardinal, and sat down. The queen took a seat in her turn.

Then, as the king looked behind him, the usher understood that look, and made a sign to the courtiers who filled up the doorway to go out, which they instantly did. Silence fell upon the chamber with the velvet curtains. The king, still very young, and very timid in the presence of him who had been his master from his birth, still respected him much, particularly now, in the supreme majesty of death. He did not dare, therefore, to begin the conversation, feeling that every word must have its weight not only upon things of this world, but of the next. As to the cardinal, at that moment he had but one thought—his donation. It was not physical pain which gave him that air of despondency, and that lugubrious look; it was the expectation of the thanks that were about to issue from the king's mouth, and cut off all hope of restitution. Mazarin was the first to break the silence. 'Is your majesty come to make any stay at Vincennes?' said he.

Louis made an affirmative sign with his head.

'That is a gracious favour,' continued Mazarin, 'granted to a dying man, and which will render death less painful to him.'

'I hope,' replied the king, 'I am come to visit, not a dying man, but a sick man, susceptible of cure.'

Mazarin replied by a movement of the head.

'Your majesty is very kind; but I know more than you on that subject. The last visit, sire,' said he, 'the last visit.'

'If it were so, monsieur le cardinal,' said Louis, 'I would come a last time to ask the counsels of a guide to whom I owe everything.'

Anne of Austria was a woman; she could not restrain her tears. Louis showed himself much affected, and Mazarin still more than his two guests, but from very different motives. Here the silence returned. The queen wiped her eyes, and the king resumed his firmness.

'I was saying,' continued the king, 'that I owed much to your eminence.' The eyes of the cardinal had devoured the king, for he felt the great moment had come. 'And,' continued Louis, 'the principal object of my visit was to offer you very sincere thanks for the last evidence of friendship you have kindly sent me.'

The cheeks of the cardinal became sunken, his lips partially opened, and the most lamentable sigh he had ever uttered was about to issue from his chest.

'Sire,' said he, 'I shall have despoiled my poor family; I shall have ruined all who belong to me, which may be imputed to me as an error; but, at least, it shall not be said of me that I have refused to sacrifice everything to my king.'

Anne of Austria's tears flowed afresh.

'My dear Monsieur Mazarin,' said the king, in a more serious tone than might have been expected from his youth, 'you have misunderstood me, apparently.'

Mazarin raised himself upon his elbow.

'I have no purpose to despoil your dear family, nor to ruin your servants.

Oh, no, that must never be!'

'Humph!' thought Mazarin, 'he is going to restore me some scraps; let us get the largest piece we can.'

'The king is going to be foolishly affected and play generous,' thought the queen; 'he must not be allowed to impoverish himself; such an opportunity for getting a fortune will never occur again.'

'Sire,' said the cardinal, aloud, 'my family is very numerous, and my nieces will be destitute when I am gone.'

'Oh,' interrupted the queen, eagerly, 'have no uneasiness with respect to your family, dear Monsieur Mazarin; we have no friends dearer than your friends; your nieces shall be my children, the sisters of his majesty; and if a favour be distributed in France, it shall be to those you love.'

as the dying man felt that the uncertainty increased his torments, he did not hesitate an instant.

'His majesty will be welcome,—yes, very welcome,' cried he, making a sign to Colbert, who was seated at the foot of the bed, and which the latter understood perfectly. 'Madame,' continued Mazarin, 'will your majesty be good enough to assure the king yourself of the truth of what I have just said?'

Anne of Austria rose; she herself was anxious to have the question of the forty millions settled—the question which seemed to lie heavy on the mind of everyone. Anne of Austria went out; Mazarin made a great effort, and, raising himself up towards Colbert: 'Well, Colbert,' said he, 'two days have passed away—two mortal days—and, you see, nothing has been returned from yonder.'

'Patience, my lord,' said Colbert.

'Are you mad, you wretch? You advise me to have patience! Oh, in sad truth, Colbert, you are laughing at me. I am dying and you call out to me to wait!'

'My lord,' said Colbert, with his habitual coolness, 'it is impossible that things should not come out as I have said. His majesty is coming to see you, and no doubt he brings back the deed himself.'

'Do you think so? Well, I, on the contrary, am sure that his majesty is coming to thank me.'

At this moment Anne of Austria returned. On her way to the apartments of her son she had met with a new empiric. This was a powder which was said to have power to save the cardinal; and she brought a portion of this powder with her. But this was not what Mazarin expected; therefore he would not even look at it, declaring that life was not worth the pains that were taken to preserve it. But, whilst professing this philosophical axiom, his long-confined secret escaped him at last.

'That, madame,' said he, 'that is not the interesting part of my situation. I made, two days ago, a little donation to the king; up to this time, from delicacy, no doubt, his majesty has not condescended to say anything about it; but the time for explanation is come, and I implore your majesty to tell me if the king has made up his mind on that matter.'

Anne of Austria was about to reply, when Mazarin stopped her.

Anne of Austria had also followed the cardinal; her heart, though age had made it selfish, could not help evincing towards the dying man a sorrow which she owed him as a wife, according to some; and as a sovereign, according to others. She had, in some sort, put on a mourning countenance beforehand, and all the court wore it as she did.

Louis, in order not to show on his face what was passing at the bottom of his heart, persisted in remaining in his own apartments, where his nurse alone kept him company; the more he saw the approach of the time when all constraint would be at an end, the more humble and patient he was, falling back upon himself, as all strong men do when they form great designs, in order to gain more spring at the decisive moment. Extreme unction had been administered to the cardinal, who, faithful to his habits of dissimulation, struggled against appearances, and even against reality, receiving company in his bed, as if he only suffered from a temporary complaint.

Guenaud, on his part, preserved profound secrecy; wearied with visits and questions, he answered nothing but 'his eminence is still full of youth and strength, but God wills that which He wills, and when He has decided that man is to be laid low, he will be laid low.' These words, which he scattered with a sort of discretion, reserve, and preference, were commented upon earnestly by two persons,—the king and the cardinal. Mazarin, notwithstanding the prophecy of Guenaud, still lured himself with a hope, or rather played his part so well, that the most cunning, when saying that he lured himself, proved that they were his dupes.

Louis, absent from the cardinal for two days; Louis, with his eyes fixed upon that same donation which so constantly preoccupied the cardinal; Louis did not exactly know how to make out Mazarin's conduct. The son of Louis XIII, following the paternal traditions, had, up to that time, been so little of a king that, whilst ardently desiring royalty, he desired it with that terror which always accompanies the unknown. Thus, having formed his resolution, which, besides, he communicated to nobody, he determined to have an interview with Mazarin. It was Anne of Austria, who, constant in her attendance upon the cardinal, first heard this proposition of the king's, and transmitted it to the dying man, whom it greatly agitated. For what purpose could Louis wish for an interview? Was it to return the deed, as Colbert had said he would? Was it to keep it, after thanking him, as Mazarin thought he would? Nevertheless,

'Smoke!' thought Mazarin, who knew better than any one the faith that can be put in the promises of kings. Louis read the dying man's thought in his face.

'Be comforted, my dear Monsieur Mazarin,' said he, with a half-smile, sad beneath its irony; 'the Mesdemoiselles de Mancini will lose, in losing you, their most precious good; but they shall none the less be the richest heiresses of France; and since you have been kind enough to give me their dowry'—the cardinal was panting—'I restore it to them,' continued Louis, drawing from his breast and holding towards the cardinal's bed the parchment which contained the donation that, during two days, had kept alive such tempests in the mind of Mazarin.

'What did I tell you, my lord?' murmured in the alcove a voice which passed away like a breath.

'Your majesty returns my donation!' cried Mazarin, so disturbed by joy as to forget his character of a benefactor.

'Your majesty rejects the forty millions!' cried Anne of Austria, so stupefied as to forget her character of an afflicted wife, or queen.

'Yes, my lord cardinal; yes, madame,' replied Louis XIV, tearing the parchment which Mazarin had not yet ventured to clutch; 'yes, I annihilate this deed, which despoiled a whole family. The wealth acquired by his eminence in my service is his own wealth and not mine.'

'But, sire, does your majesty reflect,' said Anne of Austria, 'that you have not ten thousand crowns in your coffers?'

'Madame, I have just performed my first royal action, and I hope it will worthily inaugurate my reign.'

'Ah! sire, you are right!' cried Mazarin; 'that is truly great—that is truly generous which you have just done.' And he looked, one after the other, at the pieces of the act spread over his bed, to assure himself that it was the original and not a copy that had been torn. At length his eyes fell upon the fragment which bore his signature, and recognizing it, he sunk back on his bolster in a swoon. Anne of Austria, without strength to conceal her regret, raised her hands and eyes towards heaven.

'Oh! sire,' cried Mazarin, 'may you be blessed! My God! May you be beloved by all my family. Per Baccho! If ever any of those belonging to me should cause your displeasure, sire, only frown, and I will rise from my tomb.'

This pantalonnade did not produce all the effect Mazarin had counted upon. Louis had already passed to considerations of a higher nature, and as to Anne of Austria, unable to bear, without abandoning herself to the anger she felt burning within her, the magnanimity of her son and the hypocrisy of the cardinal, she arose and left the chamber, heedless of thus betraying the extent of her grief. Mazarin saw all this, and fearing that Louis XIV might repent his decision, in order to draw attention another way he began to cry out, as, at a later period, Scapin was to cry out, in that sublime piece of pleasantry with which the morose and grumbling Boileau dared to reproach Moliere. His cries, however, by degrees, became fainter; and when Anne of Austria left the apartment, they ceased altogether.

‘Monsieur le cardinal,’ said the king, ‘have you any recommendations to make me?’

‘Sire,’ replied Mazarin, ‘you are already wisdom itself, prudence personified; of your generosity I shall not venture to speak; that which you have just done exceeds all that the most generous men of antiquity or of modern times have ever done.’

The king received this praise coldly.

‘So you confine yourself,’ said he, ‘to your thanks—and your experience, much more extensive than my wisdom, my prudence, or my generosity, does not furnish you with a single piece of friendly advice to guide my future.’ Mazarin reflected for a moment. ‘You have just done much for me, sire,’ said he, ‘that is, for my family.’

‘Say no more about that,’ said the king.

‘Well!’ continued Mazarin, ‘I shall give you something in exchange for these forty millions you have refused so royally.’

Louis XIV indicated by a movement that these flatteries were displeasing to him. ‘I shall give you a piece of advice,’ continued Mazarin; ‘yes, a piece of advice—advice more precious than the forty millions.’

‘My lord cardinal!’ interrupted Louis.

‘Sire, listen to this advice.’

‘I am listening.’

‘Come nearer, sire, for I am weak!—nearer, sire, nearer!’

Chapter XLVIII

Agony



HE day that the deed of gift had been sent to the king, the cardinal caused himself to be transported to Vincennes. The king and the court followed him thither. The last flashes of this torch still cast splendor enough around to absorb all other lights in its rays. Besides, as it has been seen, the faithful sate-

lite of his minister, young Louis XIV, marched to the last minute in accordance with his gravitation. The disease, as Guenaud had predicted, had become worse; it was no longer an attack of gout, it was an attack of death; then there was another thing which made that agony more agonizing still,—and that was the agitation brought into his mind by the donation he had sent to the king, and which, according to Colbert, the king ought to send back unaccepted to the cardinal. The cardinal had, as we have said, great faith in the predictions of his secretary; but the sum was a large one, and whatever might be the genius of Colbert, from time to time the cardinal thought to himself that the Theatin also might possibly have been mistaken, and there was at least as much chance of his not being damned, as there was of Louis XIV sending back his millions.

Besides, the longer the donation was in coming back, the more Mazarin thought that forty millions were worth a little risk, particularly of so hypothetical a thing as the soul. Mazarin, in his character of cardinal and prime minister, was almost an atheist, and quite a materialist. Every time that the door opened, he turned sharply round towards that door, expecting to see the return of his unfortunate donation; then, deceived in his hope, he fell back again with a sigh, and found his pains so much the greater for having forgotten them for an instant.

'You have yourself said why, madame,' replied Fouquet; 'because kings cannot and ought not to receive presents from their subjects.'

The king remained silent between these two contrary opinions.

'But forty millions!' said Anne of Austria, in the same tone as that in which, at a later period, poor Marie Antoinette replied, 'You will tell me as much!'

'I know,' said Fouquet, laughing, 'forty millions makes a good round sum,—such a sum as could almost tempt a royal conscience.'

'But, monsieur,' said Anne of Austria, 'instead of persuading the king not to receive this present, recall to his majesty's mind, you, whose duty it is, that these forty millions are a fortune to him.'

'It is precisely, madame, because these forty millions would be a fortune that I will say to the king, "Sire, if it be not decent for a king to accept from a subject six horses, worth twenty thousand livres, it would be disgraceful for him to owe a fortune to another subject, more or less scrupulous in the choice of the materials which contributed to the building up of that fortune."'

'It ill becomes you, monsieur, to give your king a lesson,' said Anne of Austria; 'better procure for him forty millions to replace those you make him lose.'

'The king shall have them whenever he wishes,' said the superintendent of finances, bowing.

'Yes, by oppressing the people,' said the queen.

'And were they not oppressed, madame,' replied Fouquet, 'when they were made to sweat the forty millions given by this deed? Furthermore, his majesty has asked my opinion, I have given it; if his majesty ask my concurrence, it will be the same.'

'Nonsensel accept, my son, accept,' said Anne of Austria. 'You are above reports and interpretations.'

'Refuse, sire,' said Fouquet. 'As long as a king lives, he has no other measure but his conscience,—no other judge than his own desires; but when dead, he has posterity, which applauds or accuses.'

'Thank you, mother,' replied Louis, bowing respectfully to the queen.

'Thank you Monsieur, Fouquet,' said he, dismissing the superintendent civilly.

'Do you accept?' asked Anne of Austria, once more.

'I shall consider of it,' replied he, looking at Fouquet.

The king bent over the dying man. 'Sire,' said Mazarin, in so low a tone that the breath of his words arrived only like a recommendation from the tomb in the attentive ears of the king—'Sire, never have a prime minister.'

Louis drew back astonished. The advice was a confession—a treasure, in fact, was that sincere confession of Mazarin. The legacy of the cardinal to the young king was composed of six words only, but those six words, as Mazarin had said, were worth forty millions. Louis remained for an instant bewildered. As for Mazarin, he appeared only to have said something quite natural. A little scratching was heard along the curtains of the alcove. Mazarin understood: 'Yes, yes!' cried he, warmly, 'yes, sire, I recommend to you a wise man, an honest man, and a clever man.'

'Tell me his name, my lord.'

'His name is yet almost unknown, sire; it is M. Colbert, my attendant. Oh! try him,' added Mazarin, in an earnest voice; 'all that he has predicted has come to pass; he has a safe glance, he is never mistaken either in things or in men—which is more surprising still. Sire, I owe you much, but I think I acquit myself of all towards you in giving you M. Colbert.'

'So be it,' said Louis, faintly, for, as Mazarin had said, the name of Colbert was quite unknown to him, and he thought the enthusiasm of the cardinal partook of the delirium of a dying man. The cardinal sank back on his pillows.

'For the present, adieu, sire! adieu,' murmured Mazarin. 'I am tired, and I have yet a rough journey to take before I present myself to my new Master. Adieu, sire!'

The young king felt the tears rise to his eyes; he bent over the dying man, already half a corpse, and then hastily retired.

'A gift?' repeated Fouquet.

'Yes,' said the king, replying pointedly to the superintendent of finances, 'yes, at the point of death, monsieur le cardinal makes me a donation of all his wealth.'

'Forty millions,' cried the queen. 'Oh, my son! this is very noble on the part of his eminence, and will silence all malicious rumors; forty millions scraped together slowly, coming back all in one heap to the treasury! It is the act of a faithful subject and a good Christian.' And having once more cast her eyes over the act, she restored it to Louis XIV, whom the announcement of the sum greatly agitated. Fouquet had taken some steps backwards and remained silent. The king looked at him, and held the paper out to him, in turn. The superintendent only bestowed a haughty look of a second upon it; then bowing,—'Yes, sire,' said he, 'a donation, I see.'

'You must reply to it, my son,' said Anne of Austria; 'you must reply to it, and immediately.'

'But how, madame?'

'By a visit to the cardinal.'

'Why, it is but an hour since I left his eminence,' said the king.

'Write, then, sire.'

'Write!' said the young king, with evident repugnance.

'Well!' replied Anne of Austria, 'it seems to me, my son, that a man who has just made such a present, has a good right to expect to be thanked for it with some degree of promptitude.' Then turning towards Fouquet: 'Is not that likewise your opinion, monsieur?'

'That the present is worth the trouble? Yes, madame,' said Fouquet, with a lofty air that did not escape the king.

'Accept, then, and thank him,' insisted Anne of Austria.

'What says M. Fouquet?' asked Louis XIV

'Does your majesty wish to know my opinion?'

'Yes.'

'Thank him, sire—'

'Ah!' said the queen.

'But do not accept,' continued Fouquet.

'And why not?' asked the queen.

‘I hoped, madame,’ said Fouquet, much agitated, ‘that my love for his majesty, my incessant desire to please him, would serve to compensate the want of etiquette. It was not so much a present that I permitted myself to offer, as the tribute I paid.’

‘Thank you, Monsieur Fouquet,’ said the king politely, ‘and I am gratified by your intention, for I love good horses; but you know I am not very rich; you, who are my superintendent of finances, know it better than any one else. I am not able, then, however willing I may be, to purchase such a valuable set of horses.’

Fouquet darted a haughty glance at the queen-mother, who appeared to triumph at the false position in which the minister had placed himself, and replied:—

‘Luxury is the virtue of kings, sire: it is luxury which makes them resemble God; it is by luxury they are more than other men. With luxury a king nourishes his subjects, and honours them. Under the mild heat of this luxury of kings springs the luxury of individuals, a source of riches for the people. His majesty, by accepting the gift of these six incomparable horses, would stimulate the pride of his own breeders, of Limousin, Perche, and Normandy; and this emulation would have been beneficial to all. But the king is silent, and consequently I am condemned.’

During this speech, Louis was, unconsciously, folding and unfolding Mazarin’s paper, upon which he had not cast his eyes. At length he glanced upon it, and uttered a faint cry at reading the first line.

‘What is the matter, my son?’ asked the queen, anxiously, and going towards the king.

‘From the cardinal,’ replied the king, continuing to read; ‘yes, yes, it is really from him.’

‘Is he worse, then?’

‘Read!’ said the king, passing the parchment to his mother, as if he thought that nothing less than reading would convince Anne of Austria of a thing so astonishing as was conveyed in that paper.

Anne of Austria read in turn, and as she read, her eyes sparkled with joy all the greater from her useless endeavour to hide it, which attracted the attention of Fouquet.

‘Oh! a regularly drawn up deed of gift,’ said she.

Chapter XLIX

The First Appearance of Colbert



HE whole night was passed in anguish, common to the dying man and to the king: the dying man expected his deliverance, the king awaited his liberty. Louis did not go to bed. An hour after leaving the chamber of the cardinal, he learned that the dying man, recovering a little strength, had insisted upon being dressed, adorned and painted, and seeing the ambassadors. Like Augustus, he no doubt considered the world a great stage, and was desirous of playing out the last act of the comedy. Anne of Austria reappeared no more in the cardinal’s apartments; she had nothing more to do there. Propriety was the pretext for her absence. On his part, the cardinal did not ask for her: the advice the queen had given her son rankled in his heart.

Towards midnight, while still painted, Mazarin’s mortal agony came on. He had revised his will, and as this will was the exact expression of his wishes, and as he feared that some interested influence might take advantage of his weakness to make him change something in it, he had given orders to Colbert, who walked up and down the corridor which led to the cardinal’s bed-chamber, like the most vigilant of sentinels. The king, shut up in his own apartment, dispatched his nurse every hour to Mazarin’s chamber, with orders to bring him back an exact bulletin of the cardinal’s state. After having heard that Mazarin was dressed, painted, and had seen the ambassadors, Louis heard that the prayers for the dying were being read for the cardinal. At one o’clock in the morning, Guenaud had administered the last remedy. This was a relic of the old customs of that fencing time, which was about to disappear to give place to another time, to believe that death could be kept off by some good secret thrust. Mazarin, after having taken the remedy, respired freely

for nearly ten minutes. He immediately gave orders that the news should be spread everywhere of a fortunate crisis. The king, on learning this, felt as if a cold sweat were passing over his brow;—he had had a glimpse of the light of liberty; slavery appeared to him more dark and less acceptable than ever. But the bulletin which followed entirely changed the face of things. Mazarin could no longer breathe at all, and could scarcely follow the prayers which the cure of Saint-Nicholas-des-Champs recited near him. The king resumed his agitated walk about his chamber, and consulted, as he walked, several papers drawn from a casket of which he alone had the key. A third time the nurse returned. M. de Mazarin had just uttered a joke, and had ordered his ‘Flora,’ by Titian, to be revarnished. At length, towards two o’clock in the morning, the king could no longer resist his weariness: he had not slept for twenty-four hours. Sleep, so powerful at his age, overcame him for about an hour. But he did not go to bed for that hour; he slept in a fauteuil. About four o’clock his nurse awoke him by entering the room.

‘Well?’ asked the king.

‘Well, my dear sire,’ said the nurse, clasping her hands with an air of commiseration. ‘Well; he is dead!’

The king arose at a bound, as if a steel spring had been applied to his legs.

‘Dead!’ cried he.

‘Alas! yes.’

‘Is it quite certain?’

‘Yes.’

‘Official?’

‘Yes.’

‘Has the news been made public?’

‘Not yet.’

‘Who told you, then, that the cardinal was dead?’

‘M. Colbert.’

‘M. Colbert?’

‘Yes.’

‘And he was sure of what he said?’

‘He came out of the chamber, and had held a glass for some minutes before the cardinal’s lips.’

‘Ah!’ said the king. ‘And what is become of M. Colbert?’

easy and respectful, advanced towards the queen, so as not to disturb the king. Louis had opened the paper, and yet he did not read it. He listened to Fouquet paying the most charming compliments to the queen upon her hand and arm. Anne of Austria’s frown relaxed a little, she even almost smiled. Fouquet perceived that the king, instead of reading, was looking at him; he turned half round, therefore, and while continuing his conversation with the queen, faced the king.

‘You know, Monsieur Fouquet,’ said Louis, ‘how ill M. Mazarin is?’

‘Yes, sire, I know that,’ said Fouquet; ‘in fact, he is very ill. I was at my country-house of Vaux when the news reached me; and the affair seemed so pressing that I left at once.’

‘You left Vaux this evening, monsieur?’

‘An hour and a half ago, yes, your majesty,’ said Fouquet, consulting a watch, richly ornamented with diamonds.

‘An hour and a half!’ said the king, still able to restrain his anger, but not to conceal his astonishment.

‘I understand you, sire. Your majesty doubts my word, and you have reason to do so; but I have really come in that time, though it is wonderful! I received from England three pairs of very fast horses, as I had been assured. They were placed at distances of four leagues apart, and I tried them this evening. They really brought me from Vaux to the Louvre in an hour and a half, so your majesty sees I have not been cheated.’ The queen-mother smiled with something like secret envy. But Fouquet caught her thought. ‘Thus, madame,’ he promptly said, ‘such horses are made for kings, not for subjects; for kings ought never to yield to any one in anything.’

The king looked up.

‘And yet,’ interrupted Anne of Austria, ‘you are not a king, that I know of, M. Fouquet.’

‘Truly not, madame; therefore the horses only await the orders of his majesty to enter the royal stables; and if I allowed myself to try them, it was only for fear of offering to the king anything that was not positively wonderful.’

The king became quite red.

‘You know, Monsieur Fouquet,’ said the queen, ‘that at the court of France it is not the custom for a subject to offer anything to his king.’

Louis started.

Louis looked at his mother, expecting some emotion in her voice, some sorrow in her countenance. The face of Anne of Austria appeared a little changed, but that was from sufferings of quite a personal character. Perhaps the alteration was caused by the cancer which had begun to consume her breast. 'Yes, madame,' said the king; 'yes, M. de Mazarin is very ill.'

'And it would be a great loss to the kingdom if God were to summon his eminence away. Is not that your opinion as well as mine, my son?' said the queen.

'Yes, madame; yes, certainly, it would be a great loss for the kingdom,' said Louis, colouring; 'but the peril does not seem to me to be so great; besides, the cardinal is still young.' The king had scarcely ceased speaking when an usher lifted the tapestry, and stood with a paper in his hand, waiting for the king to speak to him.

'What have you there?' asked the king.

'A message from M. de Mazarin,' replied the usher.

'Give it to me,' said the king; and he took the paper. But at the moment he was about to open it, there was a great noise in the gallery, the ante-chamber, and the court.

'Ah, ah,' said Louis XIV, who doubtless knew the meaning of that triple noise. 'How could I say there was but one king in France! I was mistaken, there are two.'

As he spoke or thought thus, the door opened, and the superintendent of finances, Fouquet, appeared before his nominal master. It was he who made the noise in the ante-chamber, it was his horse that made the noise in the courtyard. In addition to all this, a loud murmur was heard along his passage, which did not die away till some time after he had passed. It was this murmur which Louis XIV regretted so deeply not hearing as he passed, and dying away behind him.

'He is not precisely a king, as you fancy,' said Anne of Austria to her son; 'he is only a man who is much too rich—that is all.'

Whilst saying these words, a bitter feeling gave to these words of the queen a most hateful expression; whereas the brow of the king, calm and self-possessed, on the contrary, was without the slightest wrinkle. He nodded, therefore, familiarly to Fouquet, whilst he continued to unfold the paper given to him by the usher. Fouquet perceived this movement, and with a politeness at once

'He has just left his eminence's chamber.'

'Where is he?'

'He followed me.'

'So that he is—'

'Sire, waiting at your door, till it shall be your good pleasure to receive him.'

Louis ran to the door, opened it himself, and perceived Colbert standing waiting in the passage. The king started at sight of this statue, all clothed in black. Colbert, bowing with profound respect, advanced two steps towards his majesty. Louis re-entered his chamber, making Colbert a sign to follow. Colbert entered; Louis dismissed the nurse, who closed the door as she went out. Colbert remained modestly standing near that door.

'What do you come to announce to me, monsieur?' said Louis, very much troubled at being thus surprised in his private thoughts, which he could not completely conceal.

'That monsieur le cardinal has just expired, sire; and that I bring your majesty his last adieu.'

The king remained pensive for a minute; and during that minute he looked attentively at Colbert;—it was evident that the cardinal's last words were in his mind. 'Are you, then, M. Colbert?' asked he.

'Yes, sire.'

'His faithful servant, as his eminence himself told me?'

'Yes, sire.'

'The depositary of many of his secrets?'

'Of all of them.'

'The friends and servants of his eminence will be dear to me, monsieur, and I shall take care that you are well placed in my employment.'

Colbert bowed.

'You are a financier, monsieur, I believe?'

'Yes, sire.'

'And did monsieur le cardinal employ you in his stewardship?'

'I had that honour, sire.'

'You never did anything personally for my household, I believe?'

'Pardon me, sire, it was I who had the honour of giving monsieur le cardinal the idea of an economy which puts three hundred thousand francs a year into your majesty's coffers.'

'What economy was that, monsieur?' asked Louis XIV
'Your majesty knows that the hundred Swiss have silver lace on each side of their ribbons?'

'Doubtless.'

'Well, sire, it was I who proposed that imitation silver lace should be placed upon these ribbons; it could not be detected, and a hundred thousand crowns serve to feed a regiment during six months; and is the price of ten thousand good muskets or the value of a vessel of ten guns, ready for sea.'

'That is true,' said Louis XIV, considering more attentively, 'and, ma foi! that was a well placed economy; besides, it was ridiculous for soldiers to wear the same lace as noblemen.'

'I am happy to be approved of by your majesty.'

'Is that the only appointment you held about the cardinal?' asked the king.

'It was I who was appointed to examine the accounts of the superintendent, sire.'

'Ah!' said Louis, who was about to dismiss Colbert, but whom that word stopped; 'ah! it was you whom his eminence had charged to control M. Fouquet, was it? And the result of that examination?'

'Is that there is a deficit, sire; but if your majesty will permit me—'

'Speak, M. Colbert.'

'I ought to give your majesty some explanations.'

'Not at all, monsieur, it is you who have controlled these accounts; give me the result.'

'That is very easily done, sire: emptiness everywhere, money nowhere.'

'Beware, monsieur; you are roughly attacking the administration of M. Fouquet, who, nevertheless, I have heard say, is an able man.'

Colbert coloured, and then became pale, for he felt that from that minute he entered upon a struggle with a man whose power almost equaled the sway of him who had just died. 'Yes, sire, a very able man,' repeated Colbert, bowing.

'But if M. Fouquet is an able man, and, in spite of that ability, if money be wanting, whose fault is it?'

'I do not accuse, sire, I verify.'

'That is well; make out your accounts, and present them to me. There is a deficit, you say? A deficit may be temporary; credit returns and funds are restored.'

'I only paid attention to one thing, my son, and that was, that you were complaining.'

'Whol! ? Not at all,' said Louis XIV; 'no, in truth, you err, madame.'

'What were you doing, then?'

'I thought I was under the ferule of my professor, and developing a subject of amplification.'

'My son,' replied Anne of Austria, shaking her head, 'you are wrong not to trust my word; you are wrong not to grant me your confidence. A day will come, and perhaps quickly, wherein you will have occasion to remember that axiom:—"Gold is universal power; and they alone are kings who are all-powerful."'

'Your intention,' continued the king, 'was not, however, to cast blame upon the rich men of this age, was it?'

'No,' said the queen, warmly; 'no, sire; they who are rich in this age, under your reign, are rich because you have been willing they should be so, and I entertain against them neither malice nor envy; they have, without doubt, served your majesty sufficiently well for your majesty to have permitted them to reward themselves. That is what I mean to say by the words for which you reproach me.'

'God forbid, madame, that I should ever reproach my mother with anything!'

'Besides,' continued Anne of Austria, 'the Lord never gives the goods of this world but for a season; the Lord—as correctives to honour and riches—the Lord has placed sufferings, sickness, and death; and no one,' added she, with a melancholy smile, which proved she made the application of the funeral precept to herself, 'no man can take his wealth or greatness with him to the grave. It results, therefore, that the young gather the abundant harvest prepared for them by the old.'

Louis listened with increased attention to the words which Anne of Austria, no doubt, pronounced with a view to console him. 'Madame,' said he, looking earnestly at his mother, 'one would almost say in truth that you had something else to announce to me.'

'I have absolutely nothing, my son; only you cannot have failed to remark that his eminence the cardinal is very ill.'